Data Advocacy for All: Working and Teaching with Data for Social Change

Gries, Laurie
legries@colorado.edu
University of Colorado-Boulder, United States of America

Blevins, Cameron
cameron.blevins@ucdenver.edu
University of Colorado-Denver, United States of America

Fernandez, Sylvia
sylvia.fernandez@utsa.edu
University of Texas at San Antonio, United States of America

This panel brings together rhetoric, history, and digital humanities scholars who have engaged in diverse digital public-facing projects to advocate for social change and who have worked to strengthen ethical data advocacy education in higher educational settings across the United States. This panel consists of three 20-minute talks followed by a 30-minute discussion and Q & A.

In their individual talks, panel members will identify a specific research and/or pedagogical project they have worked on in recent years in effort to make a unique contribution to digital and public humanities scholarship. These open-access projects include a five-year hate-tracking project; an online educational toolkit funded by a $300,000 local grant; and a digitized dataset that contributes to a new online data repository supported by a substantive national computing grant. These talks are grounded in multiple methods (iconographic tracking; minimal computing; oral history; archival research) and multiple methodologies–from rhetorical data studies to critical data studies and data feminism and literary criticism. While the individual talks are largely descriptive, each panel member highlights their unique contribution to the digital humanities at large, whether that entails forwarding a new methodology; offering a new digital toolkit or database; or introducing a new pedagogical approach. Each presentation also makes a unique argument as to how why data advocacy research and education is critical to the digital humanities in the 21st century.

Following these presentations, panel members will engage each other and the audience with hopes of sparking a rich discussion about several different matters:

- the ethics and challenges of working and teaching with data for social change;
- the role of data activism and data advocacy in digital humanities research and education;
- and the critical needs for invigorating data advocacy education in higher education.

Overall, through both presentation and discussion, this panel hopes to expand the digital humanities arena by disclosing the diverse and significant values of data advocacy research and education.

Paper #1: Rhetorical Data Studies: A Methodological Approach for Data Activism and Advocacy

As evident in recent projects such as Torn Apart/Separados (2018) and the Virulent Hate Project, data activism (Milan and Gutierrez 2015) has become a promising means for digital humanities scholars to counter contemporary injustices within and across national borders. In contribution to such efforts, Speaker 1 forwards “rhetorical data studies” as a productive methodology for generating actionable insights and tools that can account for (and hopefully intervene in) pressing socio-political problems. To explicate this approach, Speaker 1 weaves rhetorical studies, critical data studies, and critical race theory to theorize the connections between the racial politics of circulation (Gries and Bratta 2019) and the rhetorical politics of accountability (Gries 2023). Speaker 1 then demonstrates how such approach, when coupled with iconographic tracking (Gries 2015), can be deployed for advocacy and social impact by showcasing its application in the Swastika Counter Project, a recently released digital humanities project directed by Speaker 1 that tracks antisemitism and harm across the United States and generates reliable data and resources for addressing this global socio-cultural problem. Ultimately, Speaker 1 argues that as the Digital Humanities gears up in the context of intensifying authoritarian regimes and intensifying hate-fueled violence across the world, rhetorical data studies cannot only be constructive for countering circulating acts of violence but also educating students in the critical arts of data advocacy. As evidence for the latter claim, Speaker 1 describes how working on the Swastika Counter Project inspired the co-design of the Data Advocacy for All Project, discussed by Speaker 2.

Paper #2: Data Advocacy for All: Building an Open-Access Educational Toolkit

This paper discusses Data Advocacy for All (DA4All), a digital humanities project designed to educate students in the critical practice of data advocacy: inquiring with data, communicating with data, and deploying data to create more just futures. DA4All's core project is an open-access, online toolkit of richly curated teaching resources, including readings, assignments, and lesson plans, compiled by an interdisciplinary team of faculty and librarians at two University of Colorado campuses in the United States. DA4All specifically aims to help students learn how to examine data within power structures, process data ethically and responsibly, and craft compelling data-driven narratives for social change.

DA4All argues for the importance of incorporating data advocacy into existing digital humanities pedagogy models. Moreover, the project contends that effective data advocacy education must move beyond technical training to embrace ethical frameworks and rhetorical practices. Drawing from critical data studies, data science, and rhetorical data studies, DA4All is structured around three interconnected "literacy domains" of data advocacy: Understanding Data, Processing Data, and Persuading with Data. DA4All's website outlines these domains, offers a fully searchable and filterable repository of teaching resources for each domain, and showcases student projects designed in undergraduate classes that draw on DA4All resources.

This paper presents an overview of DA4All's pedagogical principles and underlying infrastructure (including its foundation of minimal computing). It then goes on to highlight how this curriculum has been implemented in classes, including student projects that address real-world concerns by engaging with local community initiatives and global social justice campaigns. Our project ultimately argues that by expanding access to data advocacy education through projects such as DA4All, the digital humanities, as a field, has broader capabilities to impact social change.

Paper #3: Engaging with Transnational and Multilingual Data: Methodologies and Pedagogies for Developing Datasets of Gender Violence

Speaker 3 argues that digital humanities efforts to work for advocacy and social impact benefit from the development of translingual datasets that map gender violence—a practice that can be ethically undertaken in higher education courses across the world. To support this

argument, Speaker 3 first identifies constructive methodologies for engaging with transnational and multilingual data to create datasets on human rights issues like the gender violence and femicides that are happening along the Mexico-US border city of Cd. Juarez. Speaker 3 then describes a transdisciplinary, collaborative course offered at the University of Texas in the Unites States that adopted such methodologies to create a translingual dataset titled "Gender Violence at the Border (1993-1998) for the Responsible Datasets in Context project supported by the Mozilla Foundation's Responsible Computing Challenge.

The course emphasized ethical and responsible data production at the intersection of feminist

studies, literary analysis, digital humanities and data science. Students were taught how to

critically analyze a range of materials, including literary texts, archival documents, oral histories, and digital counterdata addressing gender-based violence. Through both close and distant reading, and using a series of digital tools, students developed multilingual humanities datasets and explored feminist visualizations using transnational, intersectional, and historical frameworks.

Speaker 3 argues that this type of digital humanities education is especially crucial for teaching students how to critically engage with real-world data that is often non-English and inaccessible and ethically enact responsible practices in data production for humanistic inquiry.

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